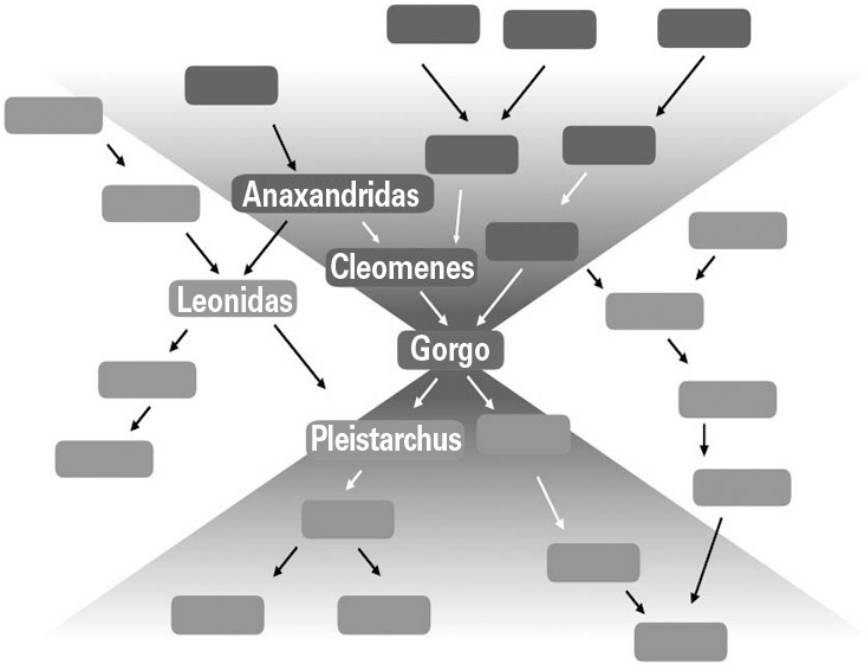
human beings (Leonidas, Gorgo, and Cleomenes come *after* Anaxandridas and *before* Pleistarchus), but not between *any* humans: Leonidas and Gorgo are neither before nor after in respect to each other.

Mathematicians have a term for the order established by filiation: “partial order.” A partial order establishes a relation of *before* and *after* between certain elements, but not between any two of them. Human beings form a “partially ordered” set (not a “completely ordered” set) through filiation. Filiation establishes an order (*before* the descendants, *after* the forebears), but not between everyone. To see how this order works, we need only think of a family tree, like this one for Gorgo:



There is a cone-shaped “past” made up of her forebears, and a “future” cone comprising her descendants. Those who are neither ancestors nor descendants remain outside of the cones.

Every human being has their own past cone of ancestors and future cone of descendants. Those of Leonidas are shown below, alongside Gorgo’s: